

HORS D'OEUVRES **DILIP BOBB**

Nouveau Niche



India has just hosted a World Toilet Summit! Amusing as it may seem, it represents a growing trend towards niche markets and products. We live in the era of the nouveau niche: from grocery stores stocked with imported exotica to products and publications for women, children, pet owners, fitness enthusiasts, technology buffs, lifestyles—you name it, they have it. It's been around in the West for a while but it's taking off in India in a major way. From TV channels peddling religion, yoga and shopping to offbeat movies, radio stations (the INDIA TODAY Group has one called Meow for women only) to alternative music, art, food and even clothes. A book called *The Long Tail* concluded that in terms of products, the head of the demand curve is getting shorter and the tail, comprising a growing array of smaller items, is getting fatter and longer. In other words, the mass market is rapidly giving way to niche markets.

There's a reason for that trend catching on in India. Consumers are more individualised than ever before, expecting goods and services to address their personal needs. Also, with less time on their hands, more purchasing power and more choices, customers prefer products that are unique and in tune with their lifestyle. A huge range of personal care products, energy drinks and health foods are flooding the shelves, catering to a smaller but growing market. The profusion of mobile phones are now so varied in terms of price and features for precisely the same reason. From a handful of TV channels a few years ago, there are now over a hundred catering to every segment of society. We also now have niche tourism, where going off the beaten track is increasingly in demand. It's the same story with restaurants serving niche customers. Like on the Internet, the name of the game is to produce something that will appeal to someone somewhere.

Gone are the traditional demographic segments: this is all about being what is called Masters of The Youniverse. The ideal is not to be like the Joneses but to be the Joneses. A decade ago, there was something called a common culture, a common ethic. It was called the Water Cooler Effect, where everyone in an office looked the same, ate similar food, saw the same movies, and so had common ground for conversation. That is no longer the case. Instead of the water cooler, India is more a hot-house, containing a variety of exotic plants each requiring different nourishment for survival. Going Nouveau Niche isn't just being different, it's also progressive.



TIRELESS: The walkathon



AFP PHOTO Tauseef MUSTAFA

Landless on the Highway

DELHI Overweight celebrities smiling incessantly into cameras while endorsing causes are commonplace at fashionable walkathons, but Janadesh (People's Verdict) 2007 was something else. It was conceived in Gwalior as the "assembly of the deprived", a campaign to mobilise landless farmers, tribes and backward castes in 2005. By October 2007, the "walk for land" had almost become a civil disobedience movement of sorts against policies of the State.

After 25,000 landless people walked for 27 days from Gwalior to reach the capital on October 28, Prime Minister Manmohan Singh was forced to think of a new rehabilitation and resettlement policy. Although a draft policy aimed at helping an estimated 43 per cent of the population has been jointly prepared by the ministries of rural development and agriculture, more consultations are pending. "We have made a good beginning. The UPA Government has promised a national policy for the

landless. As we watch the Centre, we will strengthen our movement in the states," says Ran Singh Parmar, national convener, Ekta Parishad.

This platform for the underprivileged had initiated awareness for land rights among people displaced due to reasons such as construction of infrastructure projects and creation of national parks and sanctuaries. The Parishad had conducted a similar walk from Gwalior to Delhi last year with 500 members braving the national highways across 350 km. That was a test march called Chetawani Yatra in 2006.

Janadesh was flagged off on Gandhi Jayanti this year with the landless from 60 districts of Madhya Pradesh, Orissa, Chhattisgarh, Bihar, Jharkhand, Uttar Pradesh, Tamil Nadu and Kerala joining the movement. Looking to leveraging from the walkathon, leaders of political parties extended their support. As for the aggrieved people, it is still a long walk towards the policy dawn.

by **Satarupa Bhattacharjya**